# MAJOR SUIT OPENINGS

*Note: This lesson assumes you are **NOT** playing the 2-over-1 Game Force system.*
*Note: This lesson assumes you are **NOT** playing Jacoby 2NT for strong Major raises.*
*If you are playing either of these conventions you don't need this lesson.*

## ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

Although it is not included in the Deals you might wish to examine your and dummy's hand and make a Plan of how you would play the contract.

## MAJOR SUIT OPENINGS

### Opening bids:

To open 1♥ or 1♠ you should have a least 5 cards in the suit. Any 5 cards will do, even 6 5 4 3 2.

You should also have between 13 and 21 points. Well, maybe 12 good points will do.

Here are some examples of a 1♥ opening bid.

♠ 9 8 3 ♥ A K Q 9 3 ♦ K 7 ♣ 9 7 6

♠ A 6 2 ♥ 9 8 7 5 3 ♦ A 4 ♣ A 6 5

♠ K 7 3 ♥ A K Q J 6 ♦ A Q ♣ 8 3 2

♠ 5 ♥ Q J 9 7 4 2 ♦ K Q 3 ♣ A Q 4

You might have opened hand #3 with 2NT, but probably not.

### Responses:

With fewer than three cards in partner's suit use these responses.

| Points | Response |
|---|---|
| 0-5 | pass |
| 6-10 | bid new suit at 1 level or bid 1NT |
| 11-16 | bid new suit at 1 or 2 level |
| 13-15 | bid 2NT if balanced |

If you do have at least three cards in partner's Major suit, then you already know of the 8-card fit and

can be pretty sure you will end up playing in that suit. These responses apply.

| Points | Recommended Response |
|---|---|
| 0-5 | pass with 3 or 4 card support |
| 6-10 | raise partner to 2-level |
| 10-12 | limit raise; jump to 3-level |
| 13-15 | bid a new suit (forcing) then bid 4 of the Major |
| 0-9 | bid game with 5 card support |

This set of bids isn't universally agreed.
Some don't use the weak jump to game even though it is there primarily for preemptive purposes. Others switch the third and fourth bids, using a jump to the 3-level as forcing to game and a new suit then 3 of the Major as the 11-12 point hand.

We recommend sticking to the table, and have used this system throughout the examples.

**Opener Rebids:**

Once Responder shows at least 6 points with a response Opener puts his hand into one of three categories:

| Points | Category | Rebids |
|---|---|---|
| 13-15 | Minimum | Rebid the Major suit if 6-cards<br>Bid a new lower-ranking suit<br>Bid cheapest notrump |
| 16-18 | Medium | Jump rebid a 6-card Major<br>Bid a new suit<br>Jump in NT or partner's suit |
| 19-21 | Maximum | Jump rebid a 6-card Major<br>Jump shift in a new suit<br>Jump to 3NT or game in partner's suit |

By now either Opener or Responder may be in a position to place the contract, or another bid may be needed.

**Help Suit Game Try:**

Suppose you have a hand like this:
♠A 6 ♥A K Q 9 3 ♦K 7 6 3 ♣9 3

You open 1♥ partner responds 2♥. You have agreed on the trump suit, but now have to figure out how high. You have 17/18 points and partner has shown 6-10 so you know the total is between 23 and 28. Not strong enough to bid game, but good enough to invite to game.

The "normal" invitational bid you might make is 3♥. This would tell partner to check his points and pass if he has 6 or 7, but go to game if he has 9 or 10. With 8 he would have to make a judgement call.

A better invitational bid is 3♦, a suit you could use "Help" in. This bid in no way changes the fact that you are going to end up in ♥s since that is already agreed. What it does is helps partner if he has a close call. With 9 or 10 points he should go to game regardless, but with 8 (maybe 7) he should look at his ♦ holding to see if he can help you in the suit. If so, he bids the game, if not, he returns to 3♥.

With this hand he would bid 3♥:
♠ K 7 ♥ J 8 5 4 ♦ 5 4 2 ♣ Q J 9 2

But with this hand he would bid 4♥:
♠ K 7 ♥ J 8 5 4 ♦ Q J 9 2 ♣ 5 4 2

20 examples will be worth more than another 1000 words.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6♥
Declarer: North
Lead: ♦6

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♣Q

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: South
Lead: ♦2

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: West
Lead: ♥4

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥Q

***Board 1***
North Deals
None Vul

♠ 6
♥ A Q J 9 8
♦ A K 8 5
♣ K Q J

♠ Q J 9 8 3
♥ 10 4
♦ Q J 10 9
♣ 6 4




♠ K 7 5 4
♥ 6 3
♦ 6 2
♣ 10 8 5 3 2

♠ A 10 2
♥ K 7 5 2
♦ 7 4 3
♣ A 9 7

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | 1♥ | Pass | 3♥ |
| Pass | 4NT[1] | Pass | 5♥[2] |
| Pass | 6♥ | | |
| All Pass | | | |

1. Blackwood
2. 2 aces

6♥ by North
Lead: ♦6

You dealt this hand.

This is a big hand. But not quite enough to open 2♣. So you open 1♥ and partner responds 3♥. Now what?

You might bid 4♦ as a slam try, but it is probably just as well to go ahead and ask for Aces. So you bid 4NT and partner owns up to holding 2 Aces. What is your next bid?

You have all the Aces but don't go crazy. Partner only has 11-12 points so don't think too Grand! Bid 6♥.

***Board 2***
East Deals
N-S Vul

♠ A Q 4
♥ J 4 2
♦ J 9 7
♣ K 9 7 5

♠ 9 8 7
♥ 10 8 6
♦ A Q 8 5
♣ 6 3 2




♠ K 5
♥ A K Q 7 5
♦ K 6 3
♣ A 10 8

♠ J 10 6 3 2
♥ 9 3
♦ 10 4 2
♣ Q J 4

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | 1♥ | Pass |
| 2♥ | Pass | 4♥ | |
| All Pass | | | |

4♥ by East
Lead: ♣Q

The bidding has been as shown.

With 6 points you must respond and you should let partner know you have support for his suit. So you bid 2♥ and he promptly raises to 4♥. It's a good thing he had 20 points isn't it.

***Board 3***
South Deals
E-W Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ 8<br>♥ Q 9 8 5 3<br>♦ K J 8 5<br>♣ 8 6 4 | |
| ♠ A 6 5 3<br>♥ J 6<br>♦ 10 6 2<br>♣ A 10 9 7 |  | ♠ K Q J 10 9<br>♥ A<br>♦ 9 7 3<br>♣ Q J 5 2 |
| | ♠ 7 4 2<br>♥ K 10 7 4 2<br>♦ A Q 4<br>♣ K 3 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | 1♥ |
| Pass | 4♥ | | |
| All Pass | | | |

4♥ by South
Lead: ♦2

The bidding has been as shown.

When you have a weak, distributional hand with 5 of partner's suit an immediate jump to game is usually the best approach. If he has a good hand you will probably make the contract. If he is minimum then you might get a preemptive effect and stop your LHO from entering the bidding.

This is a good example. Partner may be lucky and make 4♥. But if they had had an opportunity to compete the opponents might well be able to make 4♠.

***Board 4***
West Deals
Both Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ Q 8 5 4<br>♥ 6 4<br>♦ 10 8 6<br>♣ K J 8 2 | |
| ♠ 3<br>♥ A K J 8 7 3<br>♦ A Q J 3<br>♣ 7 3 |  | ♠ A K 9 7 2<br>♥ Q 5<br>♦ 7 4 2<br>♣ 10 6 5 |
| | ♠ J 10 6<br>♥ 10 9 2<br>♦ K 9 5<br>♣ A Q 9 4 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1♥ | Pass | 1♠ | Pass |
| 3♥ | Pass | 4♥ | |
| All Pass | | | |

4♥ by West
Lead: ♥4

The bidding has been as shown.

You can't support partner's ♥s with only 2 of them so you bid your nice ♠ suit. Partner then jumps to 3♥. Now

Here's where a lot of players go wrong. Since they only promised 4 ♠s with their first response they think they should now rebid them to show partner they had 5. And this **MIGHT** work if it turns out partner has 3 ♠s. Not only is this a risky bid, it is unnecessary. When partner jump rebid ♥s he showed 16-18 points and 6 ♥s. So you know of an 8-card fit and you know you should be in game. Bid 4♥.

***Board 5***
North Deals
None Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ A Q 10 9 3<br>♥ A 9 2<br>♦ K Q J 3<br>♣ 4 | |
| ♠ 8 4<br>♥ K 7 4 3<br>♦ A 10 8 5<br>♣ 10 7 2 | N<br>W E<br>S | ♠ 6 5<br>♥ Q J 10 6<br>♦ 9 6<br>♣ J 9 8 6 3 |
| | ♠ K J 7 2<br>♥ 8 5<br>♦ 7 4 2<br>♣ A K Q 5 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | 1♠ | Pass | 2♣ |
| Pass | 2♦ | Pass | 4♠ |
| Pass | 4NT[1] | Pass | 5♦[2] |
| Pass | 6♠ | | |
| All Pass | | | |

1. Blackwood
2. 1 ace

6♠ by North
Lead: ♥Q

The bidding has been as shown.

As soon as partner opens 1♠ you know you will settle for nothing less than the ♠ game. The problem with bidding 4♠ right now is that partner will take you for the "weak-distributional-with-five-trumps" hand. So you temporize by first bidding 2♣. Partner rebids 2♦.

You now jump to 4♠, completing the picture of an opening hand with good ♠ support. Partner bids 4NT. What say you?

This is Blackwood so you answer 5♦ for one Ace. Partner says 6♠.